



City that never sleeps: The Diary's view at 'home' has the Dubai Stadium on the right and an expansive golf village on the left. LAVANYA LAKSHMI NARAYANAN

immediately called his wife. "Gul jaan, shall we take the girls to the cricket this weekend?" he proposed. The rest of the trip passed with the fast motorways of Dubai set against the backdrop of a sweet picnic-planning endeavour.

The Diary's view from 'home' included the Dubai Stadium on the right and a sprawling golf village on the left — soon to be visited by members of the Australian women's cricket team. Practice sessions were at the ICC Headquarters, a kilometre away in the other direction. The first cricket action on the schedule was a warm-up game against South Africa, with both teams running on half a tank of gas. The slow, gripping wickets at the practice venues hinted at what was to come.

The Diary had to grudgingly miss the tournament opener in Sharjah as India's training and press meet coincided with the match in Dubai. The ICC officials were kind enough to open their boardroom — where some of the sport's biggest decisions have likely been made — for the present journalists. Arabian wraps and fresh fruit juices were on offer.

India's loss to New Zealand in its first group game raised the stakes for the clash against Pakistan. A crowd of nearly 16,000 flocked to Dubai on a hot Sunday afternoon to watch the continental rivals (though not much of a rivalry on the field) face off. A Pakistani journalist, recording his piece to camera in the stadium's expansive parking lot, remarked, "It's quite a no-contest; India is way ahead." "Arey, yeh kaise bol rahe ho paaji, dekhte jaao (How can you say that, brother? Just wait and watch)," countered a young man walking past.

Fatima Sana and her team seemed to embody that sentiment as they ran India close, ensuring anxiety at every moment in the chase. India eventually steadied the ship, earning its first points of the tournament. It was also the 100th T20I played at the venue, and the Emirates Cricket Board passed around red velvet cupcakes to mark the occasion.

The Diary, who finally met colleagues covering the women's game — people previously only seen on Zoom during press conferences — rounded off the week with an excursion to one of the city's oldest

quarters, the souks.

They were a sensory feast. Scarlet Iranian saffron and the aromas of the choicest spices enveloped the air, while some shockingly garish jewellery filled the gold markets.

Speaking Malayalam proved to be a bonus, helping secure better deals in most shops — though not in the jewellery stores. The souks had everything from ornate hijabs crafted in gold to extravagant boots and statement pieces, offering something for everyone. After exploring, the Diary found a tiny café with over 70 items on the menu. A shawarma was the first outdoor meal after days of media room food and home-cooked meals, modestly prepared to save money.

The Diary finally made it to Sharjah to watch England beat South Africa. Sharjah is a delightful venue — small and intimate, with an open press box a stone's throw from the field. The stands are so compact that surrounding buildings offer excellent views without a ticket. Family members of the England team made up most of the sparse audience and were rewarded with a win.